

TOUGH TEST
Track construction by Madras Sappers at Zojila

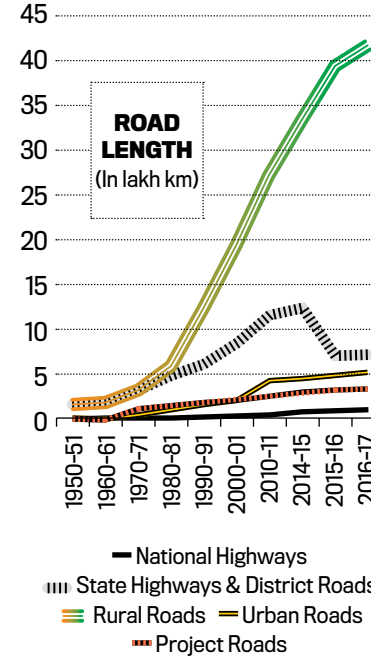
During the 2007-2017 decade, the highest compound annual growth rate (CAGR) was of urban roads, followed by rural roads and national highways. But since late last year, there has been a decline in the pace of construction. It fell to its lowest in four years to 21.3 km per day during the April-November period of the fiscal year (FY) 2021. It was 24.8 km in the same period in FY20, and 24 km/day in FY19. From the Golden Quadrilateral project launched in 2001 to the ambitious Bharatmala project, which is aiming to build 50 new national corridors, among other projects, roads and highways have been one of the most resilient sectors even during the pandemic. But the challenge for the sector has been to bring private players into road and highway construction. Land acquisition continues to be a challenge too—Bharatmala, for instance, has been running behind schedule. Its first phase is likely to be completed by 2025-26.

Private sector investment in road construction in 2020-21 and 2019-20 was Rs 12,475 crore and Rs 21,925 crore, respectively. Until November 2021, private sector investment in it was Rs 15,164 crore. The big challenge is to retain the momentum of construction, bring investments into the sector that has largely relied on government spends and further streamline land acquisition processes. Public and private investments grew at a CAGR of 21.8 per cent between 2012-13 and 2016-17, but the share of private sector investment in the construction of national highways went down from 48.35 per cent in 2012-13 to 17.37 per cent in 2016-17, while public sector investment increased from 51.65 per cent in 2012-13 to 82.63 per cent in 2016-17.

At the time of Independence, the total length of national highways was 21,378 km which is now over 1.40 lakh km. National highways are about 2.3 per cent of total road network. They carry about 40 per cent of the road traffic. ■

A ROAD TO EVERYWHERE

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MILESTONES

SETTING UP OF the National Highway Authority of India in 1989. Its job is development, maintenance and management of National Highways

NHIDCL COMMITTEE The Union Cabinet, in 2014, approved the creation and operationalisation of National Highways and Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd (NHIDCL) to improve regional connectivity in strategic areas

GOLDEN QUADRILATERAL PROJECT A NH network connecting four major metro cities of India. The project was launched in 2001

MUMBAI-PUNE EXPRESSWAY/ DELHI-NOIDA DIRECT FLYWAY

WORLI SEA LINK PROJECT, MUMBAI

BHARATMALA PROJECT For construction/upgradation of National Highways of 34,800 km over a period of five years (2017-18 to 2021-22) at an estimated outlay of Rs 5,35,000 crore